

GALLERY OF PAINTING IN LAYERS

PAINTING IN LAYERS has been integral to the art of painting for hundreds of years, and some systematic methods have evolved. The key to this technique is that each layer of paint must be completely dry before more paint is applied. There are variations on this theme, ranging from refining a simple painting with highlights and shadows, to a more complex interweaving of transparent and opaque layers of paint to create sophisticated effects. Artists evolve their own methods of working, and the images here represent a variety of approaches.



Giovanni Moroni,
*Portrait of a Widower with
His Two Children, c.1565,*
38½ x 49½ in (98 x 126 cm)

This painting has been layered in stages over a warm ground, and the depth of tone – so relevant to the meaning of the work – has been built up with transparent glazes. Bright pale tones are stacked up in opaque color to provide contrast with the background. A dramatic poignancy arises from the juxtaposition of pure, primary colors on the children's skirts with the widower's dark costume and background.



Shanti Thomas,
Fruit Stall, 26 x 30 in (66 x 76 cm)

This is an example of a work that gives a strong, direct, and immediate impression, but was in fact built up in stages. The painting relies on overlaid touches of transparent, semi-opaque, and opaque paints in a patchwork of color to create contrasted areas of tone and rich surface effects.